attack," wrote Slaughter, the captain of the submarine brought "his forward torpedo tubes to bear on *Cony*."

It was a panicky moment on board the destroyer, but the captain, Commander William Morgan, kept his cool. "*Cony*'s captain," recalled Slaughter, "directed me to apologize for the P2V's aggressive behavior." He returned to his flashing light and began transmitting the message. Luckily, it was a short one. Slaughter could hardly have imagined that he was not just clearing up a minor misunderstanding but preventing a nuclear war. The torpedo aimed at the *Cony* and the rest of the US Navy group surrounding the submarine was armed with a nuclear warhead.[2]

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THE SOVIET OFFICERS WHOM GARY SLAUGHTER HAD SEEN ON the bridge of the submarine on the night of October 27 were its captain, Valentin Savitsky, and the commander of a task force of four Foxtrot-class submarines lurking in the warm waters of the Atlantic on the approaches to Cuba, Vasilii Arkhipov. They were of equal rank, with their parade uniforms displaying the shoulder boards of captain second grade, equivalent to lieutenant colonel in the army. Savitsky was in charge of the submarine, but Arkhipov was his superior. Two captains on one ship was an arrangement that might cause trouble if their relations did not remain on an even keel.

Arkhipov was an experienced officer who had taken command of the Foxtrot group after a period of service on the first Soviet nuclear-armed and nuclear-powered submarines, which belonged to the Hotel class, according to American specifications. In July 1961, Arkhipov had been on board a Hotel-class sub designated K-19 when on its return from military exercises off the shores of Greenland one of its nuclear reactors developed a huge leak in the cooling system. The vessel had no backup system, as its construction had been rushed through, and was dogged with technical problems.

Crew members were sent into the reactor compartment to build a new cooling system in order to prevent a meltdown of the reactor. Following orders would cost them their lives. The captain of the sub, backed by